

Perplexity

A citation-first answer engine betting that owning the browsing surface matters more than owning the model · www.perplexity.ai

2022

Founded

~1,400

Employees (est.)

~\$450M+

ARR

~\$20B

Valuation

780M

Monthly queries

01 Overview

Went from a \$121M valuation in April 2023 to roughly \$20B by September 2025, on annualised revenue reported above \$450M by March 2026. The strategic bet is Comet — a free agentic browser Offering: An answer engine returning synthesised, cited answers rather than links, sold through a free tier, Pro at \$20/month, Max at \$200/month, enterprise plans, an API, and a publisher revenue-share programme.	Key facts HQ: San Francisco, California Ownership: Private. Valued at roughly \$20B in a ~\$200M round in September 2025, after earlier 2025 rounds at \$14B and \$18B; some trackers report marks above \$21B in early 2026. Total funding is reported between \$1.2B and \$1.72B depending on source. Backers include NVIDIA, SoftBank, Jeff Bezos, IVP, Accel, NEA, Databricks and Bessemer Revenue: Annualised recurring revenue reported above \$450M by March 2026, up from roughly \$100M in early 2025 and about \$63M at end-2024; some trackers put it near \$500M by mid-2026. Over \$200M of total recognised revenue in 2025 Web: www.perplexity.ai · LinkedIn Key people: Aravind Srinivas (Co-Founder & Chief Executive Officer) · Denis Yarats (Co-Founder & Chief Technology Officer) Digital twin: No · GenAI: Yes (built on third-party models)
---	---

02 Use Cases & Reported Metrics

Sector	Deployment	Reported impact	Source
Product distribution	Comet, a Chromium-based agentic browser with a sidebar assistant integrating search, task automation and multi-task management, made free worldwide in October 2025 after...	Described by the company as its highest-stakes bet; extends the product from answering questions to completing...	Link
Usage & scale	The core answer engine, used for research-shaped queries against live web sources with citations attached.	Monthly active users grew from 2 million in 2023 to 30 million by April 2025;	Link
Revenue growth	A four-line model: Pro and Max subscriptions, enterprise contracts, sponsored answers against free-tier queries, and the Comet Plus publisher revenue-share programme.	ARR above \$450M by March 2026, from roughly \$100M in early 2025; over \$200M of recognised revenue in 2025	Link

03 Competitive Landscape

Other vendors in this market: Amazon Web Services · Anthropic · Google · Meta · Microsoft · NVIDIA · OpenAI · xAI Where it sits: Perplexity does not train frontier models; it buys inference from Anthropic, OpenAI and open-weight providers and competes on interface, citation discipline and distribution. That is a real product advantage for research-shaped work — compare X to Y, what does this paper say
--

04 GIP & BlackRock Connections

GIP became a wholly-owned BlackRock subsidiary in October 2024 and now operates as BlackRock's dedicated infrastructure-investment arm. Stakes below are standard institutional/index-fund positions unless otherwise noted.	
Entity	Possible connection
Global Infrastructure Partners	No publicly disclosed GIP relationship. Relevance sits in the Individual Productivity area of the reference model — research and analysis workflows — rather than asset optimisation.
BlackRock	No publicly disclosed operating relationship.

05 Sentiment

Customer: The product has genuine loyalty for research-shaped queries, and roughly 74% of desktop visits arriving directly rather than through referral suggests habitual use rather than incidental traffic. What supports the story • ARR grew from roughly \$100M to above \$450M in about a year, driven by agents and usage-based rather than seat-based pricing • Citation-first design is a real differentiator for research work and for any use where output has to be verifiable • Comet going free worldwide is a credible distribution strategy if owning the browsing surface proves to matter	What to pressure-test • Buys most frontier inference from Anthropic, OpenAI and open-weight providers — its suppliers are also its competitors • Valued at roughly 40 to 100 times ARR depending on which figures are used, priced where foundation labs trade despite not training frontier models • Active publisher lawsuits over content scraping are unresolved and material to enterprise adoption
---	--

Employee: Not covered in this pass. Headcount is a third-party estimate of roughly 1,400, up from about 300 in 2024 — a near-fivefold increase in two years, which is worth noting as a culture and delivery...

Sources: Perplexity public filings/website, company fact sheets, Wikipedia, PitchBook/Crunchbase/Datanyze/BuiltIn profiles, Glassdoor employer reviews, vendor case studies and press releases as of Sept. 2026. Figures marked "est." or "not disclosed" are third-party estimates or unavailable — not company-confirmed — validate in diligence. Part of the Physical AI / Industrial AI for Critical Infrastructure market landscape.